warned of consequences to the airlines' credit ratings and other actions to force complete compliance.[2] Like Palau Pacific Airways, the large US companies found themselves caught in the middle of a geopolitical struggle between China and the rest of the world.

The power play was only the most recent example of China's increasingly aggressive foreign policy, and the American airlines were just the latest Western corporations to feel Beijing's wrath by not immediately capitulating to China's political agenda. Whether through economic pressure, political and military intimidation, espionage, or propaganda, Beijing is actively trying to reshape the world to fit its interests, picking and choosing which Western norms it adopts and which it ignores. Worse, while publicly proclaiming its support for global governance, Beijing appears actively antagonistic to many of the values that created the post-1945 world. As the commander of US Indo-Pacific Command, Admiral Phil Davidson, stated in July 2019, "The international order is now under assault by China."[3] China increasingly expects the world to bend to its wishes, and it has adopted a set of behaviors to ensure it gets the outcomes it wants. Call it the "new China rules." These new rules are the sources of Chinese behavior and pose the greatest strategic challenge of the next generation.

America's China Dreams

When US president Richard Nixon toasted Chinese premier Zhou Enlai during his historic visit to Peking (as it was then known) in February 1972, the veteran cold warrior had few illusions about the nature of the Chinese Communist Party (CCP) and its system. He proposed a relationship based on common interests, namely the balancing of the Soviet Union, in which Washington and Peking would pursue "different roads leading to the same goal, the goal of building a world structure of peace and justice." In reply, Zhou made clear that Peking was as wary of its potential new partner as it was of its erstwhile ally, Moscow, reaffirming that he and Mao Zedong were most concerned